

Early Temple in Mounce Block

LEWISTON LODGE HISTORY

The Lewiston Elks Lodge today occupies its fifth lodge home in its 68 years of existence. Two of the moves, the first and the last, were because of fires which destroyed lodge quarters.

A growing membership prompted the other moves.

The Benevolent and Protective Order of Elks No. 896 was chartered March 8, 1904. A class of 43 was initiated at that time and George W. Temple was the first Exalted Ruler.

Officers and members of the Moscow and Spokane Elks Lodges and William Rampton of Pocatello, a District Deputy Grand Exalted Ruler, conducted the initial ceremonies.

Annuals of the Lewiston lodge state the celebration which followed the formal events continued well into the next morning. It is recorded the closing event was a Main Street parade led by the Lewiston Military Band which started at 3:30 a.m.

The Lewiston Lodge's first home was the Masonic Hall on 1st Street between Main and D Streets. The hall was destroyed by fire in October of 1904 and the lodge took up quarters at Woodman Hall (now Knights of Pythias Hall) at 9th and Idaho Streets.

Because of a growing membership, the lodge was moved to the Mounce Building at 708 Main Street. Ironically, that structure also was destroyed by fire, in May of 1970.

Still suffering from growing pains, the lodge decided in 1921 to erect its own temple at 8th and Main Streets. That building was occupied in the spring of 1925 and dedicated in October of that year.

There the Lewiston Elks remained until fire destroyed the two-story building with full basement September 24, 1969. Lodge mementoes collected over the preceding 65 years were lost to the flames, although they gradually are being replaced.

Construction of the new temple, and equipping it, cost $1,600,000. Members will roam over a building of 35,880 square feet (on one level), compared with the 27,500 square feet of space at the former temple, which cost $67,917 to construct.

Ground was broken for the present temple June 4, 1971, by Past Grand Exalted Ruler Wm. S. Hawkins of Coeur d'Alene.

Two members of 896 have gone to grand lodge offices. Joseph A. McArthur is completing a four-year term as a grand trustee and for the last year was vice chairman of that group. Previously he was chairman of the Grand Lodge Americanism Committee and earlier had served as a committee member.

A. L. Barnes was Grand Lodge Lecturing Knight in 1943-44 and also served on the national credentials committee.

Both are former Exalted Rulers of the Lewiston Lodge.